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White-breasted Nuthatch

*Sitta carolinensis***QUICK STATS**

Length	5.1 – 5.5 in (13 – 14 cm)
Wingspan	7.9 – 10.6 in (20 – 27 cm)
Weight	0.6 – 1.1 oz (18 – 30 g)
Lifespan	Up to 10 years (avg. 2 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The White-breasted Nuthatch is one of the most distinctive and entertaining birds to visit backyard feeders — instantly recognizable by its habit of walking headfirst down tree trunks, a behavior unique among North American birds. This remarkable feat is made possible by an unusually large hind toe that provides a powerful grip regardless of orientation. Compact, neckless, and boldly patterned in black, white, and blue-gray, it is a year-round resident that pairs for life and maintains a fixed territory through all seasons. Its loud, nasal calls are among the most recognizable winter sounds in eastern North American forests.

HABITAT & RANGE

The White-breasted Nuthatch is found across most of the United States and southern Canada, from British Columbia east to Nova Scotia and south through the Appalachians and into Mexico. It inhabits mature deciduous and mixed forests, forest edges, orchards, parks, and wooded suburban gardens with large trees. It shows a strong preference for oak, hickory, and beech-dominated forests where its primary wild food — acorns and nuts — is abundant. It is a permanent resident throughout its range and does not migrate.

DIET & FEEDING

- Sunflower seeds — black-oil and striped both accepted
- Suet cakes — especially valued in winter
- Whole and shelled peanuts
- Acorns and hickory nuts (cached in bark crevices)
- Insects and spiders gleaned from bark year-round
- Peanut butter mixtures smeared into bark furrows

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

White-breasted Nuthatches are monogamous and maintain year-round pair bonds, with mates staying in close contact through constant soft calls. They are vigorously territorial, with pairs defending the same woodland territory across multiple years. Their signature head-down foraging posture gives them a unique advantage: they can spot insects and cached food items hidden in bark crevices from angles that upward-foraging birds like woodpeckers would miss entirely. They are avid food catchers, wedging seeds and nuts into bark furrows and covering them with lichen or bark fragments — a behavior that has earned them the folk name "Devil Downhead" in some regions. They often join winter foraging flocks with chickadees and Downy Woodpeckers.

NESTING & BREEDING

Breeding begins in March or April. Pairs use natural tree cavities, old woodpecker holes, or nest boxes, with the female doing most of the nest building. She constructs a cup of bark strips, grasses, and fur inside the cavity. A fascinating defensive behavior: the pair rubs crushed insects (particularly blister beetles) around the entrance hole — the noxious chemicals may deter squirrels and other predators. Clutches of 5–9 white eggs speckled with red-brown are incubated by the female for 13–14 days. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at 26 days — an unusually long nestling period.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The White-breasted Nuthatch is one of the most vocal winter birds. Its primary call is a loud, nasal "yank yank yank" — a rapid series that carries well through winter woodland. A softer, higher "ip" contact call keeps pairs in touch while foraging. The male's song, heard mostly in late winter and early spring, is a rapid series of low whistled notes "whi-whi-whi-whi" repeated several times. Females also vocalize frequently with soft nasal calls.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Stable
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The White-breasted Nuthatch population is estimated at approximately 10 million individuals and is considered stable. It benefits from the retention of large mature trees with natural cavities, and from nest box programs in managed forests. Forest fragmentation and the loss of old-growth deciduous woodland are the primary long-term concerns for this species.

FEEDER TIPS

- Offer sunflower seeds in a tube or hopper feeder near large trees
- A suet cage mounted on a tree trunk is ideal for nuthatches
- Smear peanut butter into bark crevices — they will find it quickly
- Install a nest box with a 1.25–1.5 inch entrance hole on a large tree
- Nuthatches cache seeds — place feeders near rough-barked oaks or maples

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Crown & nape (male)	Glossy black cap
Crown (female)	Dark gray — not black
Back & wings	Blue-gray
Face & underparts	White to pale
Flanks & undertail	Rusty chestnut-orange
Bill	Long, pointed, dark gray

COLOR ME!

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